

A Dhokra figurine from Odisha | © Government of Odisha/Wikimedia Commons

Casting light on Dhokra:
an intricate craft of sculpting metal

Current Conservation

@ccmagazineindia

https://twitter.com/ccmagazineindia/status/1410628921796620295?s=24

From Beeswax to Brass



Dhokra figurines | © wasim kloof/Flickr

Dhokra art utilises the lost-wax casting technique for crafting artefacts from brass.

Origins of Dhokra Art



A Dhokra cast being made by a Dharua tribal woman | © Government of Odisha/Wikimedia Commons

A 5000 year old craft, Dhokra art is named after the Dhokra Damar tribes of West Bengal and Odisha.

The themes of the metal artefacts are often mythological deities and animals.



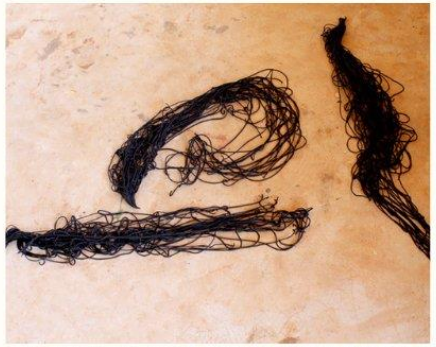
Dhokra figurines from Bastar tribes| © Sumita Roy Dutta/Wikimedia Commons

Crafting with natural materials

The base of the sculpture is made of clay and mud. Cow dung is often used in the mixture as well.



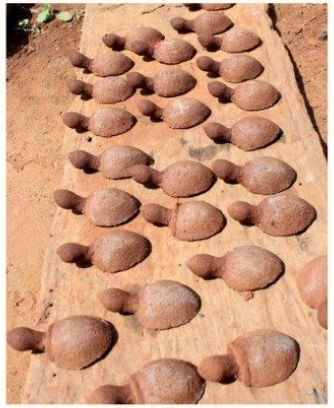
Clay is the basic raw material | © dsource.in



Threads made of beeswax | © dsource.in

Beeswax is used to create wax threads that are wound on the clay model. These are what give the sculptures their intricate details. The actual metal sculpture is made with molten brass scraps.

Preparing the moulds



Turtles made of clay | © dsource.in



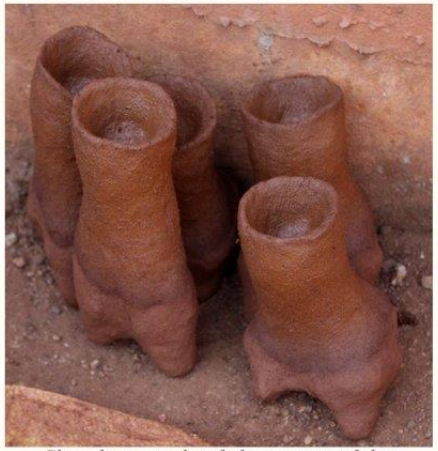
Details with wax threads | © dsource.in



Thick outer layer of clay | © dsource.in

First, a clay model is prepared and dried. Wax threads are then wound over it to detail the sculpture. Over the wax layer, a layer of riverside soil is applied. On top of this is a thick layer of clay mixed with rice husk and cowdung.

Melting the metal



Chambers made of clay on top of the models | © dsource.in



Metal scraps in the chamber will melt in the furnace | © dsource.in

A chamber made of wax and clay is added on top of the sculpture. The chamber is filled with metal scraps and the whole set up is placed in a red-hot furnace.



The wax melts away and the molten metal fills the empty space in the furnace | © dsource.in



A finished Dhokra turtle figurine | © dsource.in

Out of the furnace

The wax threads on the clay model melt away and the empty space is filled by molten metal. The burnt clay is removed and the sculpture is then polished and cleaned.

A traditional craft spanning millenia



A camel Dhokra figurine | © Priyadarshini Handlooms/Flickr



A fish Dhokra figurine | © Priyadarshini Handlooms/Flickr

Despite being a highly labour-intensive process, traditional metalsmiths in India have kept this artform alive, which has been around since the Indus valley civilisation!